

Cash Got Your Tongue?

CEO Language-Uncertainty Around
Undisclosed Cash Acquisitions

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THE EVENT CLOCK

PRIVATE COMMITMENT

EARNINGS CALL
Q&A

PUBLIC ANNOUNCEMENT

Can the spoken record reveal
what the firm withholds?



A firm knows, but cannot say

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PRIVATE

PUBLIC

THE DISCLOSURE BIND

May stay silent. If it speaks, it cannot mislead.



— Does withholding leave a trace in the CEO's language?

Conceptual setting: thesis Chapter 2; *Basic v. Levinson* (1988); Rule 10b-5.

Does the spoken record track the hidden deal?

RESEARCH QUESTION

When an acquisition is still **private**, does CEO uncertainty in unscripted Q&A rise—and does it resolve when the deal becomes **public**?

PRIOR WORK OBSERVES

Visible market and language signals

- Market prices
- Managed tone
- Deal vocabulary

LEAVES OPEN
→

THIS THESIS MEASURES

Call-specific CEO Q&A uncertainty

Residual uncertainty, net of persistent speaking style and predictable call conditions.

- Within firm
- Private → public timing

CONTRIBUTION **A within-firm language signature aligned with the private-to-public boundary.**

Positioning summarized from thesis Chapters 1–2.

Separating speaking style from call-specific uncertainty

Observed CEO Q&A uncertainty

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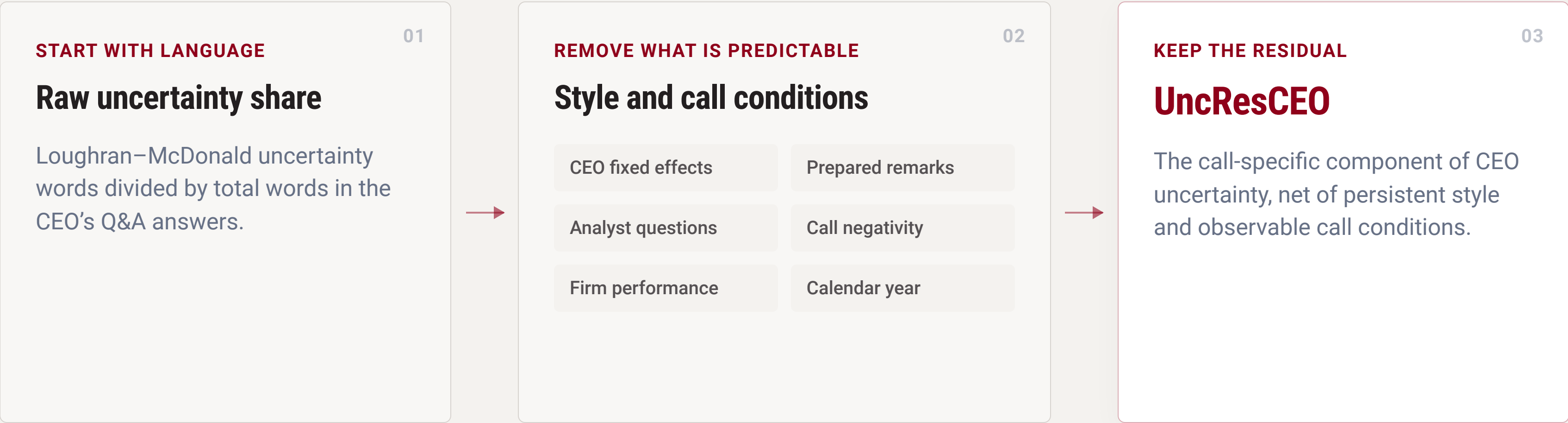
CEO style

+

Predictable call factors

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UncResCEO



Q&A only Unscripted CEO answers	≥ 5 calls Required for each CEO	State, not personality Interpreted within CEO over time
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Measure construction: thesis Chapter 3.